

POU33201 — Mid-term essay
30% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

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The short version

Weight	30% of the module mark
Length	2,000 words, 10% either way (excluding bibliography) — outside that range costs up to 5 marks
Due	Sunday 1 November 2026, 23:59
Submission	Word or PDF via Blackboard (Turnitin), Assignment Submission Form as page 1

Essay Topics

Choose **one**. Each asks you to build an argument using the academic literature — not to summarise it.

Topic 1: The Dictator's Toolkit

An autocrat can stay in power by **co-opting** rivals or by **repressing** them. Drawing on the literature on authoritarian survival, when and why do dictators rely on one strategy over the other? Illustrate your argument with at least one contemporary case.

Topic 2: Why Institutions?

Dictatorships routinely hold elections, run parliaments, and tolerate ruling parties — institutions that appear democratic but operate under authoritarian conditions. **Why?** Evaluate competing explanations (co-optation, credible power-sharing, information-gathering, signalling) and say which you find most persuasive, and why.

Topic 3: Durability vs. Fragility

Some autocracies endure for decades; others collapse with little warning. What does political science tell us makes an authoritarian regime durable — and what makes it fragile? Use the literature on breakdown, repression, and power-sharing, and apply it to **one** regime of your choice.

Topic 4: Build a Regime [TBD — pending Noah’s go/no-go, see __drafting/DECISIONS-FOR-NOAH.md]

A different kind of essay. Read the guidance below carefully before choosing it.

Pick a real country at a real moment in time — anywhere in the world, any point from 1900 to the near future — and write the counterfactual: **how would an authoritarian regime be built here, and how would it survive?**

The country may currently be a democracy (in which case you are describing an autocratisation episode) or an existing autocracy (in which case you are describing a transition from one kind of authoritarian rule to another). Your essay must answer:

1. **Where and when**, and what regime type you are moving *from* and *to*.
2. **How power is seized** — coup, self-coup, civil war, an authoritarian party, backsliding from within, or something else — and the pretext used.
3. **How the regime survives its first years** — the ruling coalition, the coercive apparatus, the basis of popular support, the international environment.
4. **How it survives decades** — which institutions, ideologies, economic structures and personalities do the work.
5. **Succession** — what happens when the leader dies or goes; this is where most regimes fail.
6. **How it might eventually end.**

This is not fiction writing, and it is not a morality tale. It’s an exercise in using the module’s toolkit — regime types, power-sharing, co-optation, repression, information control, coup-proofing — on a case concrete enough to resist hand-waving. Write as an analyst, from inside the regime’s own strategic logic; command of the theory is what earns marks.

Ground rules:

- **Your regime may not end in democratisation** — you are explaining how authoritarian rule is built and sustained.
- **Pick a real leader or real party** to head the regime wherever you can, rather than inventing someone.
- **Include one diagram** — a faction map, institutional schema, timeline, or party-system chart.
- **No “nothing went wrong” essays** (“what if the USSR never collapsed”) — clear it with me first if you want to attempt one.
- **It has to pass the smell test:** if you can’t explain the premise to a friend and have them nod, it won’t work on paper.

Two warnings, from experience with this assignment elsewhere:

- **The default answer is boring.** A Western European country, a far-right election win, capture the media and courts, stop there — it’s the Hungarian playbook, but the interesting questions (how was the election won? what do the factions want?) get skipped.
- **The more alien regimes score better.** A closed party-state or military junta forces you to specify the whole apparatus — coercion, mobilisation, ideology, succession — and that’s what shows command of the material.
- Counterfactual civil wars (“what if the losing side had won”) work for the same reason.

- No credit for a regime you think I would approve of, or for democratising early. A neutral, analytic tone throughout is what impresses.

Requirements

- A **clear thesis** stated in the introduction.
- A body organised to support that argument with **evidence**.
- **Academic literature beyond the required readings** — analysis matters more than summary.
- A properly formatted **bibliography** (any consistent style).

Marked on argument, analysis, use of evidence, structure and writing.

Submission-form category	This assessment
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Generative AI

Permissions for this assessment, in the vocabulary of the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form:

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	Always fine. No penalty and no advantage — this is not a virtue signal.
Brainstorming	Permitted. Explore angles, argue with it about your thesis, generate counterarguments to argue against.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted, with a warning. Use it to unpack a concept or a hard passage — then verify against the module readings. Do not ask it for references: it invents them, and a fabricated citation is a fabricated citation regardless of origin. Sources must be ones you have actually read.
Writing assistance	Permitted only for text you have already drafted yourself — tightening, grammar, clarity, structural critique of your own draft. Generating a section from a prompt and then editing it is not “writing assistance”; that is the next row. If you use it, add a one-line note in an appendix saying which tool and what for.
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted. No AI-generated text in the submitted essay, quoted and cited or otherwise.
Other use	Describe it on the form. If in doubt, ask me <i>before</i> the deadline; asking is never held against you.

The Assignment Submission Form must be page 1 of every written submission; a submission without a completed form is not accepted.

Late Submission

Penalties and extensions are set out in the [module outline](#): 5 marks per day, maximum 20; extensions through your College Tutor, never retrospectively.